

Linear Programming Course Summary

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1 Key Terms

1.1 Linear Programming Fundamentals

- **Slack Variable:** A variable added to a less-than-or-equal-to inequality constraint to transform it into an equality constraint. It represents the difference between the left-hand side and right-hand side of the inequality.
- **Feasible Region:** The set of all points that satisfy all the constraints of a linear programming problem.
- **Vertex:** A point where two or more constraint boundaries intersect in the feasible region of a linear programming problem. In the Simplex method, optimal solutions are found at vertices.

1.2 Simplex Method Algorithms

- **Basic Variable:** In the Simplex method, a variable that is expressed in terms of non-basic variables in a dictionary. In a basic feasible solution, basic variables are non-negative.
- **Non-basic Variable:** In the Simplex method, a variable set to zero in a given iteration of the algorithm. The values of the basic variables are determined by the values of the non-basic variables.
- **Pivot Operation:** The process of exchanging a basic and a non-basic variable in the Simplex method, leading to a new basic feasible solution.
- **Dictionary:** A representation of a linear programming problem where basic variables are expressed as functions of non-basic variables. It is used in the Simplex method to iteratively find the optimal solution.
- **Auxiliary Problem:** A modified linear programming problem introduced to find an initial feasible solution when the origin is not feasible in the original problem. It involves adding a new variable to shift the feasible region.
- **Largest-Coefficient Rule:** A pivot rule in the Simplex method that selects the entering variable with the largest coefficient in the objective function row of the dictionary.

2 Problem Types

2.1 Simplex Method Analysis

- **Worst-Case Analysis of the Simplex Method:** The Klee-Minty example demonstrates that the Simplex method can require an exponential number of iterations in the worst case, depending on the pivot rule used.
- **Impact of Pivot Rules on Simplex Method Efficiency:** Different pivot rules (e.g., largest-coefficient, largest-increase) significantly affect the number of iterations required by the Simplex method, with some rules exhibiting exponential worst-case behavior while others perform better in practice.

- **Empirical Analysis of Simplex Method Performance:** Empirical studies show that the number of iterations in the Simplex method tends to grow polynomially with the problem size in practice, even though worst-case examples exist.
- **Theoretical Bounds on Simplex Method Iterations:** Theoretical analysis of randomized pivot rules provides bounds on the expected number of iterations, which are better than exponential but not polynomial.
- **Smoothed Complexity of the Simplex Method:** The smoothed complexity analysis suggests that small random perturbations to the input data can significantly improve the performance of the Simplex method, leading to a polynomial number of iterations with high probability.

2.2 Simplex Method Mechanics

- **Finding an Initial Feasible Solution:** The Simplex method requires an initial feasible solution. If the origin is not feasible, an auxiliary problem is introduced to find a feasible solution to the original problem.
- **Handling Infeasible Origins:** The origin $(0,0)$ may not satisfy all constraints in a linear programming problem. Techniques like introducing an auxiliary problem are used to find a feasible starting point.
- **Optimizing in Higher Dimensions:** The Simplex method is extended to linear programming problems with more than two variables, requiring iterative pivoting operations to find the optimal solution.
- **Using Dictionaries to Represent Solutions:** The Simplex method uses dictionaries to represent the current solution and to perform pivot operations efficiently. Each dictionary corresponds to a vertex of the feasible region.

3 Algorithm Solutions

3.1 Linear Programming Fundamentals

- **Simplex Method:** Iteratively move from one vertex of the feasible region to another by setting non-basic variables to zero and choosing a new set of (non)basic variables to improve the objective function value. This is equivalent to moving from vertex to vertex in the feasible region.
- **Auxiliary Problem:** When the origin is not feasible, introduce a new variable x_0 and modify the constraints to create an auxiliary problem that maximizes $-x_0$. Solve this auxiliary problem to find a feasible solution for the original problem. If the optimal solution has $x_0 = 0$, then a feasible solution to the original problem is found.

3.2 Simplex Method Variants

- **Largest-Coefficient Rule:** Choose the variable with the largest coefficient in the objective function row to enter the basis.
- **Largest-Increase Rule:** Choose the variable whose entrance into the basis brings about the largest increase in the objective function.
- **Bland's Rule:** Choose the variable with the smallest index among those eligible to enter the basis.
- **Randomized Pivot Rule:** Randomly permute the indices of the variables; then use Bland's rule for entering and the lexicographic method for leaving variables.

3.3 Duality Theory

- **Weak Duality:** $c^T x \leq b^T y$
- **Strong Duality:** If (P) has an optimal solution x , then (D) has an optimal solution y , and $c^T x = b^T y$.
- **Complementary Slackness:** Primal feasible x and dual feasible y are optimal if and only if $x_j z_j = 0$ for all j and $w_i y_i = 0$ for all i .